

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Natural Revelation

When God speaks directly to people, we call it special revelation. God also speaks to everyone indirectly through natural revelation (also known as general revelation because it is given to all). This happens through the natural world God created. For example, Psalm 19 says that knowledge of God in creation is available to everyone everywhere (see Psalm 19:1-4).

Sadly, not everyone responds positively to God. Paul explains in Romans 1-3 that because of Adam's sin, all people turn away from the knowledge of God found in creation. Without God's grace, natural revelation only condemns people. As Paul says in 1:20, people "are without excuse."

God can use creation to help people realize he is the one true God. When God's grace supports and empowers this natural revelation, the world's beauty and complexity can inspire a search for the Creator. Paul appealed to natural revelation when he was in Athens as a way to introduce the good news about Jesus (Acts 17:16-31). God's revelation in the natural world and in human nature can encourage people to search for him. And then, through the special revelation God has ultimately given in his Son, Jesus Christ, people can truly know him and experience salvation.

Passages for Further Study

Psalm 19:1-4; Acts 14:15-17; Acts 17:24-29; Romans 1:19-21

Nehemiah's Confidence in God

God gave the prophet Nehemiah favor with a powerful Persian king. The king agreed to all of Nehemiah's requests (Nehemiah 1:11; 2:8, 18). Nehemiah then confidently shared his bold plan to rebuild Jerusalem's walls. The people of Jerusalem trusted God would help them succeed and protect them from enemies (2:18; 4:4-5, 9).

They continued their work despite opposition. They knew God fights for his people and disrupts evil plans (4:14-15, 20). When they completed the walls, Nehemiah acknowledged that the challenging project succeeded only with God's help (6:16).

The book of Nehemiah shows that God is all-powerful and can achieve his plans in both personal lives and nations. The prayer in Nehemiah 9 praises God for his powerful acts. God created the heavens and earth,

called Abram from Ur, and gave the land to Israel (9:6; 7-8, 22-25).

God demonstrated his power over people and creation to show care for his people in three main ways (9:9-15):

1. The miraculous signs in Egypt.
2. The parting of the Red Sea.
3. The provision of guidance, food, and water in the wilderness.

The Lord sent the Israelites into exile after many generations of sin (Nehemiah 9:32-37). Now, he was fulfilling his promise to restore them (1:8-9). Nehemiah prayed and led with confidence because he knew everything was part of God's plan.

This same trust in God led Abram to leave Ur and go to an unknown land (Genesis 12:1-3; Hebrews 11:8-10). It caused Rahab to trust God (Joshua 2:9-14; Hebrews 11:31). It prompted King Hezekiah to resist the king of Assyria, Sennacherib (2 Kings 18:1-19:37). Confidence comes when people trust God will keep his promises and complete the work he started in their lives (Philippians 1:6).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 12:1-4; Joshua 1:10-18; 2:9-14; 2 Kings 18:1-19:37; Nehemiah 1:8-9, 11; 2:8, 18, 20; 4:4-5, 9, 14-15, 20; 6:16; 9:6-31; Psalms 4:5; 9:10; 37:3; 40:3; 44:6-7; 56:3-12; 112:1-9; Proverbs 3:5-12; 16:20; 28:1, 25; Isaiah 26:3; Hebrews 11:8-10, 31; 1 John 4:17

The New Community

The New Testament emphasizes the importance of the Christian community. Cultures that focus on individuals can miss this emphasis. Although God converts and spiritually rebirths Christians as individuals, he does not want them to remain isolated (John 3:3; 1 Peter 1:23). God intends to unite us as "living stones" in his "spiritual house" (1 Peter 2:5). God no longer lives in a building on Mount Zion in Jerusalem. He now lives in and among his people through the Holy Spirit.

God promised to rebuild his temple (see Ezekiel 40-48). He fulfills this promise as he lives among his people (see John 1:14). Under the new covenant, the people themselves are the "temple." We must unite in worship, praise, and service to fulfill God's purpose. Christians share the blessing of being chosen by God to carry out his mission to the world.

1 Peter 2:9 teaches that the church now has the same special role that God once gave to Israel. The church is a "chosen people" (see Deuteronomy 7:6). It is "a royal priesthood," "a holy nation" (see Exodus 19:6). It is "God's own possession" (see Exodus 19:5).

With this special status comes the duty to share the truth about God with the nations. By worshiping together and serving in different ministries, we “proclaim the virtues of Him” (1 Peter 2:9).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 12:3; Exodus 19:4–6; Deuteronomy 7:6; 2 Chronicles 5:13–14; Isaiah 11:1–16; John 1:14; 1 Corinthians 3:9–17; 6:19; 2 Corinthians 6:16–18; Ephesians 2:19–22; 1 Peter 2:4–10; Revelation 3:12; 21:1–3, 22

The New Covenant

A covenant is a formal agreement or promise made between two parties. In the Bible, covenants are special agreements between God and people.

The old covenant refers to the agreement God made with the people of Israel at Mount Sinai after he rescued them from slavery in Egypt. The main promise of the covenant of Mount Sinai was, “I will take you as My own people, and I will be your God” (Exodus 6:7; see Jeremiah 31:33). The relationship between God and his people in the Sinai covenant included laws carved in stone and a priestly class who managed all religious institutions and activities.

The new covenant is the agreement God made with people through Jesus Christ. The new covenant would differ from the old in a key way. The new covenant would no longer be external to the worshipers but would be written on their hearts (Jeremiah 31:33). The old covenant’s major weakness was its lack of power to help people obey its commands (Romans 8:3). The new covenant would be placed inside people’s hearts and minds through the power of the Holy Spirit (Ezekiel 36:24–27).

Because of this, it would become possible for people everywhere (not just a few chosen ones) to fulfill God’s covenant plan for life. This plan is summarized in the two “Great Commandments” (Matthew 22:35–40):

1. “You shall love the LORD your God” (Deuteronomy 6:5).
2. “Love your neighbor as yourself” (Leviticus 19:18).

The new covenant would achieve what the old one intended but could not achieve. It would create new individuals and a new community. The goal is a deep transformation of sinners, starting with forgiveness of sins and leading to holiness shown by good works (Ephesians 1:4; 2:8–10).

Jeremiah 30–33 emphasizes a hopeful future for Israel. The key moment is when the Lord God promises a new covenant with his people (31:31–34). This passage points to Jesus of Nazareth, whose death would

confirm this new covenant. Jesus connected the new covenant to himself during the communion ceremony (Matthew 26:28; Mark 14:24; Luke 22:20; see also 1 Corinthians 11:25; 2 Corinthians 3:6).

Jesus’ death made him the mediator of the covenant for all who trust in him (Hebrews 8:8–12; chapter 9). Christians remember this truth each time they take Communion (also called the Lord’s Supper or the Eucharist). According to the New Testament, all Christians will know God directly through the Holy Spirit, made possible by Christ’s sacrifice. They will know him personally and experience him powerfully, unlike most people in Old Testament times.

Passages for Further Study

Isaiah 11:1–9; 54:13–15; Jeremiah 31:31–34; Ezekiel 37:24–28; Matthew 26:27–28; Luke 22:20; Romans 11:25–36; 1 Corinthians 11:23–26; 2 Corinthians 3:6–18; Hebrews 8:8–9:28

The New Order

Isaiah describes two different ways the world can be. The first way (the old order) is how things are now, where people struggle with power and difficulties. The second way (the new order) is God’s new creation that will come in the future, where everything will be fair and people will live together in peace.

When Isaiah thinks about the old way of life, he remembers:

- sadness (Isaiah 65:19).
- death (65:20)
- injustice and violence (65:21–22)
- the absence of God (65:24)

In this old way of life, people trust in their own strength and are proud.

Isaiah’s vision of the new order focuses on the Lord as the great king in holiness and glory (see 6:1–5).

God’s people experience aspects of this new order now, such as:

- God’s comfort (40:1)
- salvation (45:22)
- joy (24:14–15)
- righteousness (24:16)
- peace (26:3)
- divine blessing and protection

There are other aspects that we cannot experience yet, such as:

- the end of death (25:7–8)
- resurrection (26:19)

- the end of fighting, wrongdoing, and evil (60:18; 65:25)
- full enjoyment of God's presence (60:19).
- God ruling in his eternal kingdom without opposition (see Revelation 21-22)

Those who trust in God anticipate these things in the future.

Passages for Further Study

Isaiah 11:1; 24:14-16; 25:7-8; 26:19; 30:26; 43:18-19; 60:18-19; 62:2; 65:17-25; Jeremiah 23:7-8; 31:10-14; 2 Corinthians 3:6-11; 5:17; Hebrews 12:18-24; Revelation 21:1-22:21